

Things that go bump in the night, strange shadows on the walls, and someone following you in the dark can all strike terror in your heart. You prepare for the worst . . . As the brain recognizes the threat, your body's survival instincts kick in immediately to protect you. The process is so quick that you are instantly on high alert and ready to face your fears.

WHAT IS FEAR?

NIGHT TERRORS

FEAR FACTOR

Fear has a powerful effect on the body. Under threat, the body's internal processes change rapidly to become stronger and faster. The heart is central to this change. Stimulated by the release of the hormone adrenaline and the quick responses of the nervous system, it beats faster, increasing the levels of oxygen to the muscles and brain so that the body can either confront or escape the threat.

EYES

The pupils widen to let additional light flood in so that the threat can be identified more clearly.

BRAIN

Right away, the brain senses danger and sends nerve messages as a response throughout the body.

MOUTH

As the digestive process slows down, your mouth stops producing saliva and gets very dry.

LUNGS

Breathing deepens and quickens so that the airways inside the lungs widen, allowing oxygen into the bloodstream.

HEART

The heartbeat speeds up so that extra blood is pumped to the muscles and other key parts of the body.

STOMACH

The digestive system goes on hold and blood rushes away from it toward the muscles, creating the sensation of "butterflies" in the stomach.

HANDS

Under threat, increased nerve activity acts on sweat glands to produce more sweat and hands get especially damp.

